



Plant focus: tomatoes

Delicious and versatile, tomatoes are an ideal crop for small spaces, producing bumper yields on relatively compact plants.

BEARING BEAUTIFUL FRUITS that are both tasty and decorative, tomatoes come in a wide variety of shapes and sizes. Choose from tiny cherries, medium-sized fruits, or large beefsteaks, and look for reliable disease-resistant forms that guarantee a good crop. Tomatoes are divided into two main groups: determinate which bloom and set fruit all at once and indeterminate which grow, bloom, and set fruit until frost. Both groups should be grown in full sun in well-drained, fertile soil. For earlier fruit, start plants indoors and move them outside when soil temperatures rise above 60°F (15.5°C). Dwarf bushes and patio plants can be grown in smaller pots or hanging baskets. Indeterminate tomato varieties require long stakes, as they grow tie in the main stem to the stake, pinch out any sideshoots that form, and remove the top shoot when the stem has reached about 5ft (1.5m) in height. Water the plants regularly in summer and use a nutrient rich feed once the fruits begin to show.

FORMS OF TOMATO



Determinate tomatoes These fruit on spreading sideshoots that are allowed to grow. Insert several stakes or a cage to support the stems.



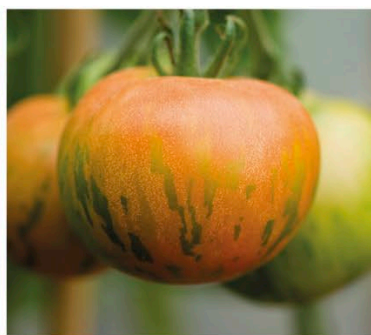
Indeterminate tomatoes Fruits are produced on a single, tall upright stem that requires support. There are many varieties to grow.



Patio crops Many compact bush varieties are ideal for patio containers and require no pinching out or staking. The fruits are small.



Colored fruits Although most varieties produce red fruits, tomatoes range in color from yellow to blackish red when ripe.



Heirloom tomatoes Many older varieties have distinctive fruits that vary from modern cultivars in size, shape, color, and flavor.

